

Arte Povera

In 1967, Italian art critic and curator Germano Celant (b.1940) described the work of several young Italian artists in Genoa, Milan, Rome and Turin as 'Arte Povera' (Poor or Impoverished Art). The artists were all working in new ways, breaking with the past, and exploring unconventional processes and 'everyday' materials such as earth, rocks, rags, rope and twigs. By using these 'poor' materials in paintings, sculpture, installations, photographs and performances, artists focused on relationships between art and life. They were also reacting against the abstract painting that dominated art at the time, and which they thought was too narrowly concerned with emotion and individual expression, and too confined by the traditions of painting. Arte Povera became the most significant and influential avant-garde movement to emerge in Europe in the 1960s. Prominent artists included Giovanni Anselmo (b.1934), Alighiero Boetti (1940–94), Luciano Fabro (1936–2007), Jannis Kounellis (b.1936), Mario Merz (1925–2003), Marisa Merz (b.1926), Giulio Paolini (b.1940), Giuseppe Penone (b.1947) and Michelangelo Pistoletto (b.1933).



Penone, Installation in the gardens of the Palace of Venaria, 1997